

# Modernism

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Following the First World War and the Russian Revolution, many in the West anticipated an era of technological, social, economic and artistic developments that would improve life for all. This utopian attitude had started with the Arts and Crafts movement and Realism, but gathered momentum with a plethora of new styles, attitudes and approaches appearing in quick succession, as artists and designers sought new forms of expression.

Rather than a style, Modernism was a loose collection of shared principles, including rejection of history and applied ornament; a preference for abstraction; and a belief that technology and design could transform society. It emerged in many areas, including architecture, literature, art and design. The architects Le Corbusier (1887–1965) and Frank Lloyd Wright (1867–1959), for instance, believed that new technology rendered old styles of building obsolete. Similarly, Modernist designers rejected superficial decoration for geometric shapes and plain materials. In Germany, the Bauhaus School epitomized Modernist ideals.



**Walter Gropius, Bauhaus building, Dessau, 1925**